THE HEIRLOOM LEDGER
Genre: Artisanal Heritage Drama / Land Title Conflict
Setting: Peri-Rural Artisan Settlement (Ideal for Majhi, Mewari, Bangru, or Malwai adaptation)
Characters: BALDEV (56), SIMRAN (26), VIKRAM (32), MUNSHI RAM (60)
Logline: When an estranged city-educated son returns with a corporate buyout offer for the family pottery workshop, his sister and traditionalist father use a century-old debt ledger to defend their heritage.

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SCENE 1: EXT. ARTISAN KILN WORKSHOP - DUSK

Smoke billows from a domed brick kiln into a violet evening sky. Dozens of unbaked clay pots sit in ordered rows on drying planks.

BALDEV (56), sinewy, hands permanently stained with red terracotta clay, checks the heat of the kiln mouth using an iron rod. A frayed cotton towel is wrapped around his neck.

SIMRAN (26), sharp-eyed and practical, sits on a wooden stool nearby. Around her neck hangs a heavy brass key on a black thread. She holds a THICK BLUE-BOUND CLOTH LEDGER, balancing a bamboo dip-pen behind her ear.

SIMRAN
The wood supplier won't wait another week, Bapuji. He wants fourteen hundred rupees before unloading the neem timber.

BALDEV
(without turning)
The kiln fire doesn't understand his calendar, Simi. When the festive pots are fired on Friday, the temple trust will settle our account.

A sleek silver hatchback stops at the dirt track outside the workshop.

VIKRAM (32) steps out. He wears crisp pressed chinos and leather dress shoes, immediately dusting off dry clay dust with a grimace. He carries a SLENDER LEATHER FOLIO.

BALDEV turns. His grip on the iron rod tightens.

BALDEV (CONT'D)
Three monsoons without a phone call, Vikram. Have you come to buy a pot or collect dust?

VIKRAM
(smiling thinly)
I came to save your knees, Father. Put the iron rod down. We need to talk inside before the village notary arrives.

Vikram taps his leather folio against his palm. Simran watches him with quiet

suspicion, sliding the blue ledger beneath her arm.

SCENE 2: INT. BALDEV'S ACCOUNT ROOM - NIGHT

A single brass kerosene lamp casts flickering amber shadows against lime-washed brick walls. Bundles of old receipts hang from ceiling rafters on wire hooks.

Baldev sits cross-legged on a jute rug. He places a HEAVY BRASS NOTARY SEAL and an open ink pad onto a low wooden teak table between them.

Vikram unzips his folio and spreads out three crisp, legal bond documents bearing red official revenue stamps.

VIKRAM
The highway bypass is cutting through the riverbed by winter. A logistics warehouse consortium has offered seventy-five lakh rupees for this two-acre plot. That's twenty-five lakhs for each of us, clear.

SIMRAN
(leaning forward, voice icy)
And what happens to the fourteen apprentice potters who sleep in the sheds, brother? Where does their fire burn?

VIKRAM
(dismissive)
They will find daily wage work at the brick kilns like everyone else, Simi. This workshop made forty thousand rupees last year! You are breaking your spine for pocket money.

Vikram slides a fountain pen toward Baldev.

VIKRAM (CONT'D)
Sign the title transfer, Bapuji. One signature, and neither of you will ever touch wet clay again.

Baldev doesn't touch the pen. Instead, he rests his calloused palm squarely over the brass notary seal.

BALDEV
Your grandfather dug this kiln with his bare hands during the great famine. Land that feeds your honor isn't traded for paper bills.

SCENE 3: INT. VERANDAH COURTYARD - EARLY DAWN

Dew glistens on the clay drying racks. The kiln embers glow a soft, dying orange.

MUNSHI RAM (60), the village elder, wrapped in a coarse wool shawl and carrying an iron-tipped walking stick, sits on a charpai sipping steaming black tea from

a steel tumbler.

Simran unlocks a battered iron trunk using THE BRASS KEY from around her neck. She pulls out the BLUE-BOUND CLOTH LEDGER, now worn at the corners.

MUNSHI RAM
Ram-Ram, Baldev-ji. Vikram called me at midnight claiming the land records were ready for certification. Is this true?

VIKRAM emerges from the guest room, carrying his leather folio under his arm, looking confident.

VIKRAM
Munshi-ji, you have the village land registry copy. Here are the transfer deeds signed by me as elder son and legal heir. We only require Father's thumb impression or seal.

SIMRAN
(stepping forward, opening the ledger)
Turn to page forty-four, Munshi Uncle. The 1974 settlement covenant.

Munshi Ram adjusts his thick bifocals and leans over the blue ledger. Simran points with her finger.

SIMRAN (CONT'D)
The land is registered under the artisan guild collective trust, not an individual. If any partner sells their share to a non-artisan, sixty percent of the proceed goes straight to the village widow fund, and the title requires unanimous consent of all resident potters.

Vikram's face pales. He lunges slightly forward.

VIKRAM
That covenant is forty years old! Modern corporate land law supersedes village guild charters!

MUNSHI RAM
(firmly closing the ledger)
Not in this sub-district, son. The district magistrate ratified this guild trust in the revenue gazette. Your bond papers are useless without the guild's unanimous blessing.

SCENE 4: EXT. DRY RIVERBED EMBANKMENT - MIDDAY

Harsh noon light bakes the cracked mud embankment beside the workshop. Heat mirages shimmer over the distant highway construction cranes.

Baldev stands at the edge of the embankment, watching the workers prepare the second kiln. His khadi shirt is soaked in sweat.

Vikram stands beside his car, tie undone, suitcase loaded in the boot. He holds the rejection memo stamped with THE HEIRLOOM BRASS SEAL in red ink.

VIKRAM
You think you won today, Simran. But the city is coming. If not this warehouse, then a railway siding. How long will your clay cups stand against concrete?

SIMRAN
As long as people thirst for clean water from an earthen pitcher, brother.

Baldev walks up to Vikram. He doesn't raise his voice. He reaches into his pocket and pulls out a small, terracotta oil lamp—freshly fired, glowing warm terracotta red. He presses it into Vikram's palms.

BALDEV
Take this to your high-rise apartment in the city, Vikram. When the power goes out and the air turns to smoke, light it. Remember whose clay you were molded from.

Vikram looks down at the fragile lamp in his manicured hands. His jaw works silently. He turns, enters his car, and drives away, leaving a swirl of golden dust on the road.

Baldev and Simran stand shoulder-to-shoulder, watching the dust settle over the firing kilns.